DAY 7 OF 30

Shortcuts: use data without copying it

Data stays where it is.
Fabric reads it in place.

ADLS | Amazon S3 | Google Cloud

Keshav Maheshwari
Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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THE PROBLEM

Most pipelines exist only to copy data.

1	**Step one**	Copy it from the other cloud
2	**Step two**	Schedule the copy
3	**Step three**	Fix the copy when it breaks
4	**Step four**	Explain why the copy is stale

Two copies cost twice the storage, and **they are never quite the same.**

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Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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THE SIMPLE VERSION

A desktop shortcut to a file.

A shortcut on your desktop is not the file. It is a signpost. Double-click it and you open the real thing.

A OneLake shortcut does the same for **a folder or table that lives somewhere else**.

✓ **Looks like**	A normal folder in the lake
✓ **Actually is**	A pointer to the source
✓ **Copies made**	None

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Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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HOW IT WORKS

What a shortcut can point to

1. Another **lakehouse or warehouse** in OneLake
2. **Azure Data Lake Storage** and Blob Storage
3. **Amazon S3** and S3-compatible storage
4. **Google Cloud Storage**
5. **OneDrive, SharePoint, Dataverse**, and on-premises via gateway

Delta is recognised

Put a shortcut to a Delta table under Tables, and it behaves like a native table.

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FOR ENGINEERS

The parts that trip people up

Identity depends on the target

Shortcuts inside OneLake check the calling user. External ones use the stored connection's credentials.

Deleting has two meanings

Removing the shortcut leaves the source untouched. Deleting a file inside it deletes that file at the source.

Speed is the source's speed

Queries still read from the other cloud, with its latency and egress cost. Caching is available for some sources.

Format still matters

A shortcut to CSV gives you files, not a table. Delta or Parquet is what makes it queryable.

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Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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THE HONEST PART

Shortcut or copy?

SHORTCUT	COPY THE DATA
Data is already in Delta or Parquet	The source is slow or far away
Another team owns and maintains it	You need to reshape it heavily anyway
You want zero duplication	The source may change without warning

> **The catch:** a shortcut makes you depend on someone else's storage. If they rename a folder or rotate a key, your reports break and nothing in your workspace changed.

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Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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WATCH OUT

Four things to check first

1. **Who owns the connection** an external shortcut relies on
2. **Egress charges** when the source is in another cloud
3. **Access rules**: who can now reach the data through you
4. **A plan** for when the source moves or changes

A shortcut removes the copy, **not the dependency**.

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Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

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SAVE THIS

Shortcuts in five lines

1. **A pointer**, not a copy
2. **Works across** OneLake, Azure, AWS and Google
3. **Delta targets** behave like native tables
4. **Performance** follows the source
5. **Ownership** of the source still matters

Tomorrow: Medallion architecture. Bronze, Silver, Gold, and what each layer is for.

Keshav Maheshwari
Data Engineer | Databricks · AWS & Azure · Streaming · Applied AI

Follow for Day 8